PRODUCT DELIVERY

Stakeholder and Team Collaboration

Mapping stakeholders by influence and interest, managing expectations through transparency, and connecting the team's work to the product vision.

Knowing your stakeholders

No product decision happens in a vacuum. A Product Owner constantly balances the needs of users against the expectations of a wider set of stakeholders, and doing that well starts with knowing who those stakeholders actually are and what they care about.

Stakeholder mapping

Stakeholder mapping is a simple way to make this explicit. Stakeholders are plotted on two dimensions: their level of interest in the product, and their level of influence over its success. Someone with high influence and high interest needs to be closely engaged and involved in key decisions. Someone with high influence but lower day-to-day interest needs to be kept satisfied and informed at the right moments, without being pulled into every detail. Someone with high interest but limited influence benefits from being kept informed, since they can be a useful source of feedback and advocacy. Someone with low interest and low influence needs only light, occasional monitoring. Mapping stakeholders this way prevents the common trap of spending equal effort on everyone, when in practice attention needs to be distributed deliberately.

Managing expectations

Managing expectations well depends on transparency. Stakeholders tend to lose trust not because priorities change, since that is normal in product work, but because they are surprised by changes they were not prepared for. Sharing the reasoning behind decisions, not just the decisions themselves, and revisiting commitments openly as new information arrives, keeps that trust intact.

Collaboration within the team

Within the team, collaboration works the same way it does with external stakeholders: it depends on shared understanding of why work matters, not just what work is scheduled. A Product Owner who consistently connects day-to-day backlog decisions back to the product vision and current goals gives the team a basis for good judgement even in moments when the Product Owner is not in the room.

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